Lexical Task Heads on Simple Tasks

Schematic project summary

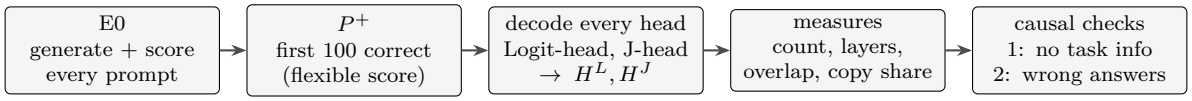
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Marks: ✓ works / supports the hypothesis, ✗ does not, ∼ mixed or task-dependent. Full methods and tables: `proposal-simple.tex`. The complex tasks are summarised in `summary-complex.tex`.

1 Setup in one page

Question	Does the lexical-task-head method of Yang et al. (2026) reproduce on our setup, does Head-JLens (J-head) find heads the per-head logit lens (Logit-head) misses, and which heads should be kept when a task is asked for in several wordings?
Model	Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct (bf16; only model with released Head-JLens matrices).
Readouts	Logit-head: head write $c_{l,h}$ decoded by the unembedding. J-head: head output $z_{l,h}$ mapped through the fitted Jacobian $J_{l,h}$, then decoded.
Simple tasks	14 Todd et al. tasks (antonym, capitals, translation, ...). Rule style: 5 instruction templates; example style: 1/5/10/20/30 shots; zero-shot prompt. Raw text, no chat template.
Head criterion	Head is a lexical task head on a prompt if ≥ 1 of its top-10 tokens is in the task's term list; for the style if this holds on $\geq 10\%$ of P^+ (first 100 correct prompts of the most accurate wording).
Term lists	Yang et al.'s (2–22 token ids).
Causal check 1	Yang App. G.1: patch the mean head output ($\times\alpha$) at the last token of prompts *without* task info; control = mean of another task at the same heads.
Causal check 2	Yang's released script: patch prompts that *give* the task but were answered wrongly (baseline 0).
Head sets patched	H^L, H^J, and J-only $H^J \setminus H^L$.



2 Experiments and outcomes

Experiment	Design	Outcome (short)	
E0 — behavioural baseline			
Simple tasks	14 tasks × 11 prompts, every item.	All tasks well above zero-shot; accuracy rises 1→5 shots then flat. Template spread largest on translation, next/prev-item, park–country, synonym.	✓
Scoring audit	Every reply saved; strict (first token) vs flexible vs GPT-5.5 judge; disagreement reasons.	Translation spread mostly quotes/capitals; first-token score marks any number correct.	✓

E1 — simple tasks (14 tasks × rule/example × 2 readouts)

Experiment	Design	Outcome (short)	
Head sets	100 prompts per style; most accurate template / 5-shot.	Logit-head finds heads on every task. J-head finds more on 23/28 pairs; its extra heads sit in layers 10–19 (Logit-head mostly ≥20). J-head contains all of Logit-head only on 4/28. Example heads mostly inside rule heads.	✓
Check 1 (zero-shot)	Means per wording, 15 α values, control mean.	Logit-head: gain ≥10 items on capitals, landmark, park, product (+ currency, next-item, plural with examples). Nothing on antonym, synonym, present–past, prev-item, translations. Best around $\alpha = 4$. Control mostly low (not on park–country, next-item).	∼
Check 1, J-head	same	J-head ≥ Logit-head on most tasks; J-only heads have effects of their own.	✓
Cross-style means	Rule heads × example means and vice versa.	Same tasks gain, often as much or more.	✓
Check 2 (1-shot wrong)	Yang's released script, no control.	Gains on all 14 tasks; reproduces Yang's Figs. 57/62 task order. J-head far stronger on next/prev-item with examples.	✓
E1b — heads from several templates (rule style, simple tasks)			
$k = 5$ (all templates)	Heads passing under all 5 templates; both checks.	Better on fact tasks (capitals, park, product) only; worse elsewhere. Beats E1 on ≤4/14 tasks.	✗
$k = 1$ (union)	Exploratory.	Helps J-head on present–past (0→16 items), synonym, prev-item, control flat. Hurts Logit-head on fact tasks.	∼
$k = 3$	Exploratory.	Mostly the E1 heads; behaves like E1.	–
$k = 1$, shared	J-head union, kept only heads in the union sets of ≥ 2 tasks (keeps 15–62 of 19–74 heads per task); both checks.	**Not successful.** Removes most of the union's gains: present–past 16→1 items (check 1), 0.64→0.45 (check 2); synonym 0.21→0.13. Only country–capital rises (0.60→0.69). Shared heads do not carry the task better.	✗
$k = 1$, 4 present–past heads	The 4 heads only present–past's union set contains (L19H10, L19H24, L20H28, L21H9; none in E1); both checks, present–past only.	Check 1: no effect alone (0.01); needs the other 15 heads too. Check 2: 0.63, as the whole 19-head union (0.64); rises with α up to 10, real past forms (60/61 distinct replies); $\alpha = 0$ gives 0.02.	∼
Replies, present–past	Each patched reply sorted by kind, per head set and α (J-head, rule means; notebook below).	Shared heads make the model *name* the task ("past tense of assess": 65% of replies in check 1, 73% in check 2 at $\alpha = 10$) without doing it. The 4 unshared heads make it give *a form of the input*: from a bare prompt it repeats the verb (44%), when the prompt shows the task they fix the inflection. Together (union) they give the answer. One task; heuristic reply kinds.	–
Replies, all tasks	Same, every task.	Many patched replies contain the expected answer after a prefix the flexible score rejects ("Capital – Tbilisi", "plural needles", "Country – Russia, . . . "): 19–33% of E1 J-head replies at $\alpha = 4$ on capitals, landmark, antonym, synonym, singular–plural. Not all are answers ("opposite of solid" for *hollow*).	–
Retrieval heads	Yang et al.'s retrieval heads (their code): Definition 1 with the prompt's own answer token as target, on E1's identification prompts; overlap with every lexical set, against layer-matched chance.	Mostly distinct from lexical task heads: 2–9% of each set's heads are retrieval heads, at chance under Logit-head (0.6–1.2×), slightly above under J-head (1.1–1.7×, highest for $k = 5$). None on the translation tasks. Of the 4 present–past unshared heads only L21H9 is one (15% of prompts).	–
4 heads split	Present–past, both checks: L21H9 (the one retrieval head of the 4) alone, and L19H10, L19H24, L20H28 alone.	L21H9 carries the effect: check 2 0.60 alone (4 heads 0.63, 3 heads 0.24); in check 1 it alone makes the model repeat the verb (44% at $\alpha = 10$), as the 4 heads do, and the 3 heads do nothing. A retrieval head that brings the input word forward; the inflection comes from the prompt's example (check 2) or the shared heads (check 1).	∼

Experiment	Design	Outcome (short)	
$k = 1$ without retrieval heads	$k = 1$ sets (L and J) minus every retrieval head of the task (any template, either readout): 51/389 L and 84/672 J heads removed, none on translations; both checks, all tasks.	Mostly small changes, but task-dependent. Landmark–country collapses (check 1: L 0.72→0.02, J 0.75→0.13; J replies still name the country, not first). Present–past J loses its gains (L21H9 removed). Gains on synonym J (0.21→0.32), product–company J (0.35→0.48, control 0.10) and prev-item J check 2 (0.12→0.45, at α 9–10, no constant answer). Park–country L: control now above task. Unchanged sets reproduce $k = 1$ exactly. Broad removal: retrieval heads of E1's template and the same readout only would remove 12 L and 51 J heads.	∼

3 Hypotheses

H1 replication	Holds with Yang's released setting (check 2); fails with the procedure their paper describes (check 1: no gain on 7 tasks).	∼
H2 J-head ⊇ Logit-head	Fails: J-head misses part of the Logit-head set on 24/28 pairs. J-only heads are causal in both checks.	✗
H3 all-template heads	Falsified: better on ≤4/14 tasks.	✗

4 Design variants tried

Date	Tried first	Replaced by	Why / effect
10-27	Rules as main style, examples secondary	Rule and example treated alike	No main condition (user decision).
10-28	Prompts and means pooled over wordings	One wording for heads, one mean per wording (Yang's code)	Matches the source exactly.
10-28	Yang's batching without attention mask	Padding masked	Model attended to padding.
10-28	Check 1 only (zero-shot)	Check 1 + check 2 (released script)	Only check 2 reproduces Yang's figures.
10-30	First-token (simple) / strict (complex) score for heads and checks	Flexible score; E1, E2 rerun	Strict scoring created spurious wording differences.
11-02	E1b with $k = 5$ only	$k \in \{1, 3, 5\}$	After $k = 5$ failed; exploratory.

Inspecting replies: `notebooks/patching_outputs.py` (marimo) shows the simple-task patched replies for every manipulation: task, check, procedure (E1, $k = 1/3/5$, shared/unshared), readout, head and mean style, mean source and wording, α; accuracy, the share of the most common reply, reply kinds, and each item's replies.

5 What seems to work, what does not

- ✓ **Scoring matters first.** Flexible scoring removes most of the apparent wording sensitivity; always check it before reading wording effects.
- ✓ **Released-code setting (check 2)** is what reproduces Yang et al.; the paper's zero-shot check works only on fact-like tasks.
- ✓ **J-head on simple tasks:** more heads, earlier layers (10–19), and the added heads carry the task causally. It does not contain the Logit-head set.
- ∼ **Which heads to keep** depends on the task type: all-template heads for fact tasks, union of templates for morphology-like tasks under J-head.
- ∼ **Retrieval heads** (heads that already write the answer token) are few among lexical task heads, but some effects rest on them: landmark–country's on its 10, present–past's union gain on L21H9. Elsewhere removing them changes little or helps (synonym, product–company, prev-item under J-head). Entity-answer tasks may be carried by retrieval more than by task heads.
- ∼ **Two roles on present–past** (one task): heads shared across tasks make the model *name* the task; L21H9 makes it give *a form of the input*. Either alone fails from a bare prompt; with an example in the prompt, L21H9

alone suffices.

- **Read the replies, not only accuracy:** 19–33% of patched replies on several tasks contain the answer after a prefix the flexible score rejects, and part of a "loss" can be a format change (landmark–country under J-head). `notebooks/patching_outputs.py` shows them.

Not pursued: function vectors, function-specific heads, hidden-state differences (scope, 10-27); fp32 Head-JLens fit (≈136 GPU-h, declined); hand-labelled validation of the judge.